STEPHANIE TOWCH

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Portfolio | LinkedIn | ResearchGate | ORCID

PROFILE

ESRC-funded PhD researcher in Psychology at Birkbeck, University of London, investigating work addiction and its associations with health and wellbeing. Published researcher and conference presenter with expertise in quantitative research methods, including psychometrics, structural equation modelling (SEM) and machine learning. Experienced in R, Python, Mplus, SPSS and Qualtrics, with research spanning scale validation, systematic reviews and predictive modelling.

Research Interests: Work addiction and behavioural addictions; health psychology; work psychology; quantitative research methods; psychometrics; machine learning.

Previously spent 16 years at JPMorgan Chase in commodities operations, change management and technology project management. Interested in postdoctoral research opportunities in academia and research-focused roles in industry, particularly those involving quantitative methods, behavioural research, and health and wellbeing.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (SELECTED)

2024-2027 **PhD Researcher (ESRC-funded)** | Psychological Sciences, Birkbeck, University of London - London, UK

2023-2024 **Research Assistant & Teaching Assistant** | Psychological Sciences, Birkbeck, University of London - London, UK

2014-2020 **Project Manager** | Global Finance Technology, JPMorgan Chase Bank - London, UK

2012-2013 **Change Manager** | Finance & Business Management, JPMorgan Chase Bank - London, UK

2007-2012 **Trader's Assistant** | Commodities Exotics Middle Office, JPMorgan Chase Bank - London, UK

EDUCATION

Oct 2023-Jul 2027 **PhD Psychology** | Birkbeck, University of London - London, UK

Jul 2024-Sep 2027 **MA Social Science Data Analysis** | University of Essex - Essex, UK

Grade: Distinction, thesis pending. Modules: Web scraping and data management; confirmatory factor analysis and structural equation modelling; machine learning for social scientists; machine learning for estimating treatment effects from observational data.

Jul 2023 **International Business Global Academy** | Southwestern University of Finance and Economics - Chengdu, China

Oct 2021-Sep 2023 **MSc Organisational Psychology** | Birkbeck, University of London - London, UK

Grade: Merit. Thesis: "Exploring the relationship between work addiction and burnout."

Oct 2019-Sep 2021 **MSc Psychology** | Birkbeck, University of London - London, UK

Grade: Distinction. Thesis: "The effect of selective attention on auditory processing: Detection accuracy of task-relevant frequencies versus task-irrelevant sounds."

Sep 2001-Aug 2005 **BA (Hons) Financial Services** | Bournemouth University - Bournemouth, UK

Grade: 2:1, including French for Business. Thesis: "Afterwork: Final Salary versus Defined Benefits Pension Scheme."

SKILLS

- **Research Methods:** Quantitative Research, Psychometrics & Scale Validation, Structural Equation Modelling (SEM), Machine Learning, Causal Machine Learning for Estimating Treatment Effects & Predictive Modelling, Statistical Analysis, Systematic Reviews
- **Software and Data Analysis:** R programming, Python, Mplus, SPSS, Qualtrics
- **Subject Expertise:** Work Addiction & Behavioural Addictions, Health and Wellbeing, Psychology of Work
- **Professional Skills:** Project Management & Change Management, Finance and Commodities Operations, Stakeholder Management, Business Process Improvement, Training & Mentoring

PUBLICATIONS, CONFERENCES & ACADEMIC CONTRIBUTIONS

Publications:

- Towch, S. V., Atroszko, P. A., & Pontes, H. M. (2026). The psychometric properties of the International Work Addiction Scale (IWAS) using CTT and IRT in a nationally representative UK sample. Assessment, https://doi.org/10.1177/10731911261447068
- Towch, S. V., & Pontes, H. M. (2025). Measuring ICD-11 Burnout: The Development and Validation of the Burnout Syndrome Test in a Nationally Representative Sample. International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11469-025-01603-1
- Towch, S. V., Atroszko, P. A., & Pontes, H. M. (2024). Exploring the Relationship Between Work Addiction and Burnout. International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11469-024-01397-8

Publications Under Review:

- Towch, S. V., & Pontes, H. M. (TBC). A systematic review of work addiction and workaholism with implications for health and wellbeing. International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction.
- Towch, S. V., & Pontes, H. M. (TBC). Predicting gambling disorder severity using machine learning: the role of gaming disorder, lootboxes and psychological characteristics. International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction.
- Towch, S. V., Atroszko, P. A., Pontes, H. M., Buźniak, A., Czerwiński, S. K., Schneider, Z, Woropay-Hordziejewicz, N. A., Charzyńska, E. (TBC) Item-Level Precision of the International Work Addiction Scale: Short-Form Efficiency and High-Information Severity Indicators Across 85 Cultures.
- Pontes, H. M., & Towch, S. V. (TBC) Examining the gateway hypothesis linking gaming disorder and gambling disorder via microtransactions: A two-wave longitudinal study. Addiction.

Conference Presentations:

- Presented "The psychometric properties of the International Work Addiction Scale (IWAS) using CTT and IRT in a nationally representative UK sample" at the International Conference on Behavioral Addictions (ICBA) in Istanbul, Turkey (Aug, 2026).
- Presented "Exploring the relationship between work addiction and burnout" as part of the symposium on workaholism and its organisational implications at the EAWOP conference in Prague, Czech Republic (May 2025).
- Presented "The Measurement of Work Addiction: IWAS-7 vs BWAS" at the EAWOP Small Group Meeting 2025 on workaholism research, University of Gdansk, Poland (September 2025).

Peer-Review Activities:

- Reviewer for Australian Psychologist and the International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction.

GRANTS AWARDED

Oct 2024-Jul 2027 **ESRC-funded studentship (£100,000)** | UBEL Doctoral Training Partnership
PhD Psychology, Birkbeck, University of London

LICENCES & AFFILIATIONS

- Aug 2022 - Graduate Member (GMBPsS), British Psychological Society; Credential ID 507539.
- Jan 2025 - Graduate Member, European Association of Work and Organizational Psychology (EAWOP).
- Jan 2023 - Assistant Test User (ATU), Test User Occupational Personality (TUOP) and Test User Occupational Ability (TUOA), British Psychological Society.
- 2015 - Project Management Professional (PMP) Certification course.

LANGUAGES

French - Good command